



MENU

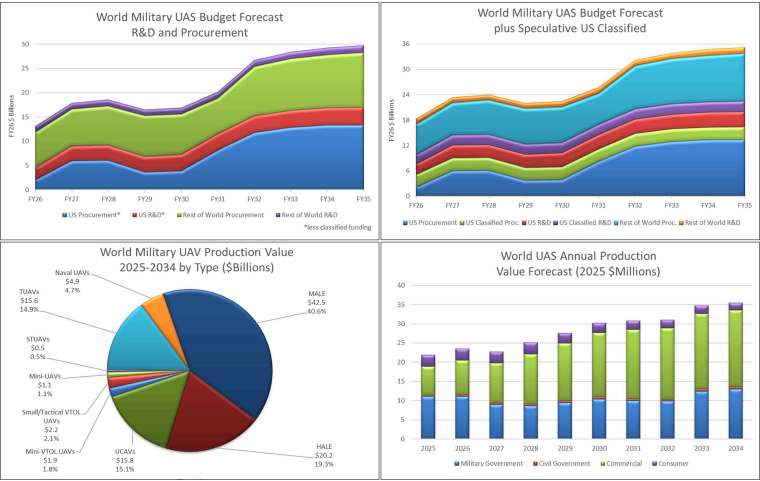


11 December 2025

2025/2026 Military UAS Sector Study RELEASED

Author: Dr. David L. Rockwell (/index.php/about/analysts/dr-david-l-rockwell)
Steven J. Zaloga (/index.php/about/analysts/steven-j-zaloga), Drawn From:
2025/2026 World Military Unmanned Aerial Systems Market Profile &
Forecast (<https://shop.tealgroup.com/products/wmuav>)

The content presented below is taken from
Teal Group's
*2025/2026 World Military Unmanned Aerial
Systems Market Profile & Forecast*
(<https://shop.tealgroup.com/products/wmuav>)



In terms of worldwide military budgets, the unmanned aircraft systems (UAS) segment continues to see growth, although annual growth has moderated when compared to a decade ago. The unclassified sector will continue to increase over the next decade, by 127.3%, more than doubling, from current annual spending on RDT&E and procurement of an estimated \$13.1 billion in FY26 to about \$29.7

billion in FY35 (a CAGR of 9.6%). If operations and maintenance expenditures were to be added, these totals would be greater. (Note: we use the US fiscal year cycle here as the standard for comparison purposes, even though each country uses its own budget cycle.)

This growth is being driven by the continued adoption of unmanned aerial systems (UAVs) worldwide. Over the next decade, unclassified US procurement will grow modestly, until FY30 when potential Collaborative Combat Aircraft (CCA) procurement could substantially boost the topline. Another big issue for the US drone sector is the extent of secret “black” drone programs.

CCA aside, growth will increasingly shift towards international markets as more militaries adopt the lessons of Iraq, Afghanistan, Syria, Libya, Nagorno-Karabakh, and Ukraine and incorporate UAVs into their forces. The introduction of specially built unmanned combat air vehicles (UCAVs) also promises to drive growth over the next decade.

Our research finds that the US will account for 70.3% of the unclassified R&D spending on UAV technology over the next decade, and about 47.4% of the unclassified procurement through the forecast decade. These US UAV funding shares for R&D and procurement represent slightly smaller shares of the market compared to defense spending in general. The US accounts for about 75% of total overall worldwide defense R&D spending and 33% of defense procurement spending, according to Teal Group’s International Defense Briefing forecasts.

The military UAS percentages change significantly when adjustments are made for US classified UAV development and procurement funding. The value of these “black” programs can only be surmised. With these assumptions, the US accounts for 80.6% of the world R&D on UAVs and 55.2% of the procurement.

This difference is due to the heavier US investment in cutting-edge technologies and the marked lag time in such research and procurement elsewhere, especially major aerospace centers such as Europe. This follows trends in other cutting-edge technologies observed over the past decade by Teal Group analysts in such areas as precision-guided weapons, information and sensor technology, and military application of space systems.

Teal Group expects that the sales of UAVs will follow recent patterns of high-tech arms procurement worldwide, with Europe representing the second largest market, followed by the Asia-Pacific region. Indeed, the Asia-Pacific region may represent an even larger segment of the market, but several significant players in the region, namely Japan and China are not especially transparent about their plans compared to Europe. As in the case of many cutting-edge aerospace products, Africa and Latin America are expected to be very modest markets for UAVs.

Some warnings are needed when viewing the our forecast. There appear to be wide swings and dips in unit acquisition over the forecast decade, that is not matched by similar swings in the production value. This is primarily due to the volatile mini-UAV market, which represents exceptionally large numbers of air vehicles even though unit costs are extremely low compared to other UAVs, especially the endurance types. It is also important to note that we are not including forecasts for inexpensive nano-UAVs.

World Military Unmanned Aerial Systems Market Profile &

Forecast (<https://shop.tealgroup.com/products/wmuav>) is an annual sector study that allows clients to identify lucrative potential business opportunities in the increasingly dynamic international military UAS market. It contains a wealth of timely intelligence and analysis on the systems, as well as requirements on a country-by-country basis.

Posted in: News Briefs (/index.php/teal-group-media-news-briefs-2/teal-group-news-media)

About the Author



(/index.php/about/analysts/steven-j-zaloga)

Steven J. Zaloga (/index.php/about/analysts/steven-j-zaloga)

Steve assumed responsibilities for the **World Missiles Briefing** (<https://shop.tealgroup.com/collections/world-missiles-uav>) during the summer of 1993. He also developed and maintains the **International Defense Briefing** (<https://shop.tealgroup.com/products/international-defense-briefing>), and is co-author of our annual sector study, **World Military Unmanned Aerial Systems Market Profile & Forecast** (<https://shop.tealgroup.com/products/2017-world-military-unmanned-aerial-systems-market-profile-forecast>).



(/index.php/about/analysts/dr-david-l-rockwell)

Dr. David L. Rockwell (/index.php/about/analysts/dr-david-l-rockwell)

Dr. David L. Rockwell has been at Teal Group since 1995, where he is author of Teal's three new ***Military Electronics Briefing (MEB)*** (<https://shop.tealgroup.com/products/military-electronics-briefing>) segment briefings – ***C4I & Electronic Warfare Systems, Electro-Optical Systems, and Radar & Sonar Systems*** – as well as co-author of Teal's annual ***World Military Unmanned Aerial Systems: Market Profile and Forecast*** (<https://shop.tealgroup.com/products/wmuav>). He also contributes regular monthly military electronics ***News Briefs*** (/index.php/teal-group-media-news-briefs/teal-group-news-media) to the Teal Group website.



Respected Analysis

Highly respected analysis and opinions on global aircraft supply and demand and the competitive profiles of leading manufacturers.



UAS/UAV Authority

The leading authority on the global markets for Unmanned Aerial Systems (UAS) and Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAV), including military, government and commercial markets.



Comprehensive Coverage

The industry's most comprehensive coverage of the global aerospace sector, including military and civilian markets.



3900 University Drive, Suite 220

Fairfax, Virginia 22030

[Send Email Message \(/index.php/pages/contact\)](/index.php/pages/contact)

Toll Free: (888) 994-TEAL (8325)

Tel: (703) 385-1992

Fax: (703) 691-9591

[Shop All \(https://shop.tealgroup.com/\)](https://shop.tealgroup.com/)

[Help & FAQ \(https://shop.tealgroup.com/apps/help-center\)](https://shop.tealgroup.com/apps/help-center)

[At-A-Glance Pricing \(http://www.tealgroup.com/index.php/at-a-glance-price-list\)](http://www.tealgroup.com/index.php/at-a-glance-price-list)

[Privacy Policy \(/index.php/pp-tos\)](/index.php/pp-tos)

[Terms of Service \(/index.php/pp-tos#tos\)](/index.php/pp-tos#tos)

[Sitemap](#)

© 1988 - 2026 Teal Group Corporation

JOIN OUR MAILING LIST FOR 3-4 UPDATES PER YEAR



[\(https://visitor.r20.constantcontact.com/d.jsp?llr=u78ucgdab&p=oi&m=1102936960916&sit=lwtx9uyeb&f=8df30bef-9202-4584-8018-067ee2afb19c\)](https://visitor.r20.constantcontact.com/d.jsp?llr=u78ucgdab&p=oi&m=1102936960916&sit=lwtx9uyeb&f=8df30bef-9202-4584-8018-067ee2afb19c)